Portrait of a Ministry Team

No one can do the work alone: God uses faithful helpers, a team with Jewish and Gentile members, strengths and weaknesses, and a family of believers who care for one another, fulfill their ministry and rest in His sufficient grace.

Where this study fits

Colossians · twelve studies · this study highlighted

01 1:1–8
Faith, Love, and Hope in Colossae

02 1:9–14
Paul’s Prayer for the Colossians

03 1:15–23
The Savior of the Gospel

04 1:24–29
Christ in You, the Hope of Glory

05 2:1–7
The Believer’s Education

06 2:8–15
Beware of Philosophy

07 2:16–23
Run the Race Set Before You

08 3:1–11
Looking Up, Putting Off

09 3:12–17
Service Manual for the Lord’s Army

10 3:18–4:1
The Relationships of the New Man

11 4:2–6
Perfecting the Prayer Life

12 4:7–18
Portrait of a Ministry Team

Tychicus: a certain kind of helper

Colossians 4:7–8 · Outline I.A–B

1	**A beloved brother** From Asia; with Paul on the third journey (Acts 20:4) and in Rome (Eph 6:21–22)	**ἀγαπητός** beloved
2	**A faithful servant** Trusted with the collection (Acts 20:4; 24:17) and with inspired letters — Colossians, Ephesians, likely Philemon	**διάκονος** ministering servant
3	**A fellow bond-servant in the Lord** Same level as Paul, same Master — no hint of rivalry	**σύνδουλος** co-slave
4	**His purpose** Carry the letter, report on Paul, bring news both ways, encourage their hearts (cf. 2:2)	**παρακαλέω** encourage

Onesimus: help from an unlikely source

Colossians 4:9 · Outline I.C — God supplies help for the helper

What he was	What grace made him
A runaway slave from a Colossian household — Philemon’s	Found by God and brought to Paul and the gospel (Philem 10)
He had wronged his master and fled (Philem 18)	“Our faithful and beloved brother, one of your number”
Under Roman law, facing severe punishment	A trusted messenger, carrying Philemon’s letter
Fled to Rome to get lost in the crowd	Safety in numbers on the road home with Tychicus

vs

God’s grace transforms people with a past into partners in ministry.

The team photograph

Colossians 4:10–14 · Outline II — Front row Jewish, back row Gentile

1 Aristarchus — a heart

συναιχμάλωτος
“My fellow prisoner”; seized at Ephesus (Acts 19:29), sailed with Paul to Rome

2 Mark — a future

ἀνεψιός
Turned back once (Acts 13:13), restored — later “useful to me” (2 Tim 4:11)

3 Jesus Justus — a name

“The Lord is salvation” (Matt 1:21); with these, Paul’s only Jewish fellow workers — a comfort

4 Epaphras — a passion

ἀγωνίζομαι
Always laboring in prayer that they stand mature and fully assured

5 Luke — a gift

ἰατρός
“The beloved physician” and careful historian (Luke 1:1–4)

6 Demas — a weakness

No description at all — later he deserted, “having loved this present world” (2 Tim 4:10)

Instructions to the family

Colossians 4:15–18 · Outline III

v.15	Greet the brethren — adelphoi, “from the same womb”: born of God; the same care for one another (1 Cor 12:25)	**ἀδελφοί** born of the same parent
v.15	Nympha and the church in her house — the early church met in homes (NKJV: Nymphas … his house)	**—** textual variant
v.16	Read the letters — Colossians in Laodicea; the “letter from Laodicea” here (likely Ephesians)	**—** cf. Rev 3:14–22
v.17	Archippus: “Take heed to the ministry … that you may fulfill it” — received in the Lord	**διακονία** significance · source · success
v.18	Paul’s own hand · “Remember my imprisonment” · “Grace be with you”	**μνημονεύω** authentic · real chains · abounding grace

If God calls us to a task, He equips us for it: “I will be with you” (Exod 3:12).

Colossians in review: Christ is all

Colossians 1–4 · The twelve studies

Doctrine — chapters 1–2

Christ supreme in creation, Church and cross (1:15–23)

Christ in you, the hope of glory (1:27)

All the fullness of Deity in Him — and you complete in Him (2:9–10)

No shadow, rule or vision can add to Him (2:16–23)

Practice — chapters 3–4

Seek things above; put off the old, put on the new (3:1–17)

Serve the Lord Christ at home and at work (3:18–4:1)

Pray, walk wisely, speak with grace (4:2–6)

Work as a team, fulfill your ministry, rest in grace (4:7–18)

We are not what we were. We are what we are. We shall be what we will be — all by the grace of God.

Discuss and apply

Colossians 4:7–18 · from the study's posted questions and applications

Discuss

1. How does Onesimus’s story display the grace of God?

2. What warning does Demas give us, and how does 1 John 2:15–16 help explain it?

Apply

Give People a Second Chance
Reach out to encourage one believer who is trying to make a fresh start.

Fulfill Your Ministry by Grace
Write your ministry in one sentence, share it with your group, and ask them to hold you accountable.

In one line: No one can do it all — God builds a team of grace and calls each member to fulfill the ministry received from Him.